

MANEESH AGNIHOTRI



**"IF WE ARE ELECTED,
 WE WILL SHAKE THE
 walls of Parliament to bring
 about a qualitative change
 in every sphere of life."**

OMENDRA BHARAT, POLITICIAN, 31

Set up in 2006 by six highly-qualified youngsters, the Bharat Punarnirman Dal (BPD) aims at freeing Indian politics from the clutches of crooks and criminals and bringing about fundamental changes in the system. The founders—Omendra Bharat, 31, from IIT-Kanpur; Ajit Ashwalayan Shukla, 30, from IIT-Bombay; Mahesh Patil, 28, a chemistry graduate; Puneet Nath Shukla, 38, a doctor; Ravi Kishen, 30, from IIT-Bombay; and Geeta Gokhle, 32, an engineering graduate from Nanded University—could have easily opted for well-paid jobs in their professional domains, but chose to wander through the dusty bylanes of the country. The reason for this, as Bharat says, is, "Our politicians get elected by practicing a divide-and-rule policy. Instead of building the nation, they break the walls of the people's houses." This year, he will contest the Lok Sabha elections from Kanpur to prove he can be different.

The party finances its social and political activities through small public donations and contribution from friends and colleagues. Spread over seven states, BPD's charter says that it seeks to establish a one-nation, one-vision, one-law country and is opposed to the present reservation policy as "it benefits undeserving people". And it has tasted success too. The party won two seats in the biennial Legislative Council polls in Andhra Pradesh in 2007. One day, the BPD hopes, it would force a change and usher a "modern, powerful nation".

by Farzand Ahmed

Matter of Policy

The party is in favour of the Indian Army launching an offensive in Pakistan to destroy all the terror camps operating on its soil.

KK NAJEEB

**"THE STUDENT
 MOVEMENT IS YET TO
 gain its full potential. Only
 10 per cent students are
 politically organised."**

**P.K. BIJU, STUDENT
 LEADER, 34**

This man with a choleric frame and beaming smile is a walking testimony to opportunities for young people in politics. P.K. Biju, 34, national president of Student Federation of India (SFI), can never be accused of setting his sights too low. He now heads Asia's largest student union with 44 lakh members and is his party's trump card in the forthcoming general elections. Biju started off with all the accompanying snags of a Dalit childhood. When a private management school refused him admission, he had to walk 2 km daily



to the government school he ended up at in Mannanam. He only had one change of clothes. Until he got to post-graduation, there was no electricity at home. He joined the SFI, CPI(M)'s student movement, when he got into K.E. College in Mannanam. He was elected its district president when he was studying for an M.Sc. degree at the Mahatma Gandhi University in Kottayam. Last year, he was elected its national president. As part of his doctoral degree, Biju is now trying to develop a blend of pvc and natural liquid rubber. On the political front, he is the CPI(M)'s candidate from Alathur in Kerala. He is confident of his victory. "I will see you in Delhi after the polls," he says. For a young man who took the odds in his life head-on, he cannot be blamed for being confident.

by Shafi Rahman

Humble Beginnings

Since there was no electricity at his home, Biju's father used to sit near him with a kerosene lamp while he spent his nights studying.